

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Fall Series 2

Painting the Stars ~ Toward Healing the Rift

13 September 2026



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540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
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The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Today we honor Meg Quinn Coulter's 75 years of membership in our community and celebrate her 88th birthday

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Improvisation on SLANE and BROTHER JAMES' AIR

Six movements from *Stabat Mater* by Giovanni Battista Pergolesi:

- Grave in F minor
- Andante amoroso in C minor
- Larghetto in G minor
- Largo in G minor
- Largo in F minor
- Allegro in G minor

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

Rev. Lehman & Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

It is not as though
we stop and start our way through life,
jerking this way and that,
half yanking our feet from one course
and onto another.

It is not as though we go so far and then,
consulting our maps,
make a sudden turn
and head off in a new direction.

It is not as though
we choose each new beginning
from a menu of life's options.

And yet
each moment opens soft and pure
awaiting our response;
each day lifts its head from the dew-strung grasses
and offers new hope, new possibility, extra chances;
each idea stirs a constellation of thoughts into being
and we are captivated by their courses.

*May we know and celebrate new beginnings
in our lives and the lives of others
and as we do,*

*may we honor what has passed
and hallow its traces
through our lives, our hearts, our loves.*

*To this we commit ourselves
as those who begin anew this day.*

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering** *The Sun is On the Sea and Shore*
The sun is on the sea and shore, a new day has begun
With morning hymns we will adore the blessed Three-in-One;
And we shall praise you ever more, until the day is done.

BROTHER JAMES' AIR

Your love is ever in our view, like shining stars by night
Your gifts are every morning new, Oh God of love and light;
Your mercy, like the heavens blue, fills our dazzled sight.

We do not know what grief and care each coming day may bring;
The heart shall find some gladness there that trusts you in each thing;
The life that serves you everywhere will never cease to sing.

***Children's Conversation & Prayer of Awareness**
Holy One,
We pause and listen to the sound of silence in this place...

Claire Kelly

We remember creation's beauty
the searing of shooting stars,
the colors of the planets in the night sky,
the space and power beyond our perceiving,
and with these memories, we are moved to prayer -
to praise the mystery of creation,
and to be grateful for the mystery of our life in this place.

May it ever be so.
May it ever be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

**Following this conversation, children are invited to join us for our Sunday morning programming.
If you were unable to check your children in prior to the service, please accompany them to our
Children's Welcome Table and check them in before returning to the service. Children must be
picked up after worship before you head to Coffee Hour.*

***Introit** Ubi Caritas
Dr. Ianthe Marini, Conductor

MAURICE DURUFLÉ

Where Charity and Love are, God is there

***The Lord's Prayer**

Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz

*Weaver of Life, Ancient and Unfolding,
How sacred is your Presence!
We lean on your guidance.
We seek your love.
We open to your transformation.
Provide us bread in body and spirit
to sustain us in faith and solidarity.
Companion us with grace
as we seek to live lives of forgiveness and compassion,
repair and accountability.
We remember those who have supported us
as we seek to support others
in all the mess and glory of this human journey.
Guard our minds and hearts from the temptation of domination
and turn our loyalty away from the systems of evil.
For the whole cosmos hums with your wisdom.
Everything that lives, returns to your care.
Our thanks and honor to you,
Gracious Web of Existence,
Our Source and our Home.
Amen and Amen.*

[enfleshed]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Lehman

In the center of the whirlwind
lies an eye.
Still.
Open.
Calm.
Before we come into the world,
it is as though we live in that center –
no worries,
no storms,
only peace.

As we find our way in life,
even in the midst of chaos,
may we remember that center
and, as the need arises,
and it must,
may we hold
to the calm, open, stillness,
knowing it as home.

[adptlvf/gvosper]

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Welcoming New Members

Rev. Lehman

*Bobby Chun | Flower Chun | Dan Cox
Alina Sunoo | Jack VanderGriend*

Beloved friends, we gather as one, woven together by the threads of love, justice, peace, and hope. Today, we are overjoyed to welcome these new members into our sacred community:
With open hearts and joyful spirits, we welcome you!

Each of you brings your unique story, faith, experience, insights, questions, enthusiasm, and gifts. Already, you are a blessing to all of us.
Together, we will welcome and celebrate your gifts, as we deepen our spiritual journeys, build community, and work for justice.

May you always find this community a place of belonging and acceptance, where you are known and cherished exactly as you are.
We promise to welcome and celebrate the fullness of who you are, and journey with you, celebrating your joys, and accompanying you in your struggles.

In the spirit of Christ's radical welcome, we say:
*Welcome to the table of love. Welcome to the work of peace.
Welcome to the church. You are home.*

Readings from Our Tradition

Rev. Lehman & Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz

from On the Origin of Species by Charles Darwin "Conclusion"

from the Gospel of John

from John 1

Rev. Lehman

In the beginning was the Word;
the Word was in God's presence,
and the Word was God.
The Word was present to God
from the beginning.

Through the Word
all things came into being,
and apart from the Word
nothing came into being.
In the Word was life,
and that life was humanity's light.

This is the Gospel of Grace.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People
Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Rev. Lehman

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Gathered in this place:
We acknowledge
a Power, a Presence
within us
within all people,
a creative, energizing Presence,
Divine,
bonding everything that exists
through patterns of attraction and co-operation,
in endless movement
toward new possibilities,
creating an interrelational universe
that makes human life possible.

*Conscious of this Divine presence
within and among us,
we open ourselves to new possibilities.*

We expand our minds,
we embrace change,
we take risks,
we discard what no longer gives meaning to life,
we deepen our awareness and appreciation
of this Presence
emerging in us.

*On this day, we give thanks for the wonderful human gift
of conscious awareness.*

We give thanks, that in us,
the universe has found a way to reflect upon itself,
to sing, to dance,
to celebrate the joy of sound and movement,
to consciously love,
to be enthralled by the creation of new life
and new possibilities.

We open ourselves to the challenge
of fully co-operating with the energizing, creative,
Divine Presence in our own personal development,
in our relationships with all other people
and in our connectedness with and care for planet Earth.

*To all that is,
and to all that could be
through the power of the Presence
within all things,
we say, Amen.* [mmoorwood]

Meditation Anthem

There is a Balm in Gilead
Tiffany Ho, *Soloist*, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor*

TRADITIONAL AFRICAN-AMERICAN
SPIRITUAL arr. WILLIAM DAWSON

Sermon

Toward Healing the Rift

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Lehman & Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz

We give thanks, Great Transformer.
You are the power that turns helium and hydrogen
into starfields,
and exploding stars into building blocks of life.
You are the intelligence that, through deep time,
turns lava into llamas,
and bacteria into Beethoven's symphonies.

At the Cana wedding,
Jesus turned water into wine,
the miracle being not the transformation
(for this is your signature),
but the time it took –
the wink of a mother's eye.

And so this morning as we gather at this table,
we know, Holy One, that in your hands,
we too may be transformed, and learn again
that you have saved the best in us for last.

Prayer of Blessing

Words of Invitation

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity

Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz

In the rising of the sun and its setting,
in the glow of the moon and its seasons,
in the infinity of space and its shining stars,
we experience God with gratitude.

This morning, we are here to remember
the harmony of heaven in the relationships of earth,
and to respond to the expanse of this mystery
within ourselves and within each other.

Our offerings and gifts are essential part of this remembrance.
We give thanks to God for this life we are privileged to share,
and we give from our resources to ensure that this congregation -
continues to grow in its commitment
to being a place where all God's children
are celebrated and loved.

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

The Peace of Wild Things MICHAEL CONLEY, TEXT: WENDELL BERRY
Laude, Rohan Ramanan, Oboe, Dr. Ianthe Marini, Conductor

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!

Alleluia! Alleluia!

till suns shall rise and set no more.

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Offering Prayer**

Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz

Holy One,
we give thanks for the people gathered
around us today.
We give thanks for the things of the earth
that support and sustain us
and make life abundant.

Help us, O God, to see our place
among these gifts.
May we not squander them
or use them for selfish gains.

Instead help us to respect the life
of all you have made.

*May our spirits now be strengthened
by the sharing of our gifts and resources
and may we use all that we have,
and all that we are,
to help those who need us.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

Deep peace of the running wave to you...
Deep peace of the flowing air to you...
Deep peace of the quiet earth to you...
Deep peace of the shining stars to you...
Deep peace of the One who is peace to you...
both this day and in all the days to come.
Amen and Amen! [adapt/gaelicblessing]

Choral Response

A Gaelic Blessing
Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor*, Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organ*

JOHN RUTTER

***Hymn for the Journey**

Wake Now My Senses

SLANE

Wake now my senses, and hear the Earth call,
feel the deep power of being in all,
keep with the web of creation your vow,
giving receiving, as love shows us how.

Wake now my reason, reach out for the new,
join with each trav'ler who quests for the true,
honor the beauty and wisdom of time,
transcend our limits and touch the sublime.

Wake now my vision, the dream we hold dear,
brighten our pathway with radiance here,
journey together with all who will share,
love for the planet transformed by our care.

--lyrics Mikelson

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*
Amen (Giovanni Battista Pergolesi)

Inside The Music

"Each musical element of our service today explores some aspect *towards healing the rift*. In Maurice Duruflé's *Ubi Caritas*, he sets the famous 8th century chant melody, which in itself is a musical setting of the ancient text *Ubi Caritas et amor, Deus ibi est—where charity and love are, God is there*. Historians of chant surmise that this text has been sung since the 4th century and is a musical rendering of the 1st century verse in 1 John 4:8 which explores The Divine as *Love* itself. In Duruflé's setting, the choir alternates between communal chant and homophonic strophic hymn singing—a representation that love and charity and the exploration of The Divine as both takes form both individually and collectively. There is a magic in singing an idea from the 1st century which took form as a poem in the

4th and later a chant in the 8th, to a choral piece in the 1960s sung in our space today in 2026. We are interconnected through the ancestral breath of *LOVE*, and it is from there that we sing.

William Dawson's setting of the 19th century African-American Spiritual *There is a Balm in Gilead* is an expression of healing as resilience through faith. *Is there no balm in Gilead?* — Cries the Hebrew Scripture in Jeremiah 8:22 amidst great spiritual and social unrest of the time. This cry translates to the prayer of the enslaved in our own country that *yes — there IS a Balm to heal the sin-sick soul*. "*Sin*" here is used to describe that which separates us from the Divine: cruelty, injustice, enslavement.

At the offertory, we hear the poetic rendering of words by the late Wendell Berry, environmental activist, farmer, and inspiration and friend guide to our work here at First Church. *"When despair for the world grows in me, I go and lie down where the wood drake rests in his beauty on the water and the great heron feeds. I come into the peace of wild things who do not tax their lives with forethought of grief. For a time I rest in the grace of the world and am free"*, he writes in his own poetic understanding of *healing the rift*. And finally, we sing John Rutter's setting of *The Gaelic Blessing* which we have spoken together many times: words that come to us from the ancestors of the Celtic tradition, exploring our inherent goodness and our interconnectivity with the sacred Earth. *Deep Peace of the running wave, the quiet earth, the shining stars to you.*" ~ Dr. Ianthe Marini

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